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1 TODO Butler, Judith. *Bodies That Matter*. 1993.

1.1 overview:

The book explores sex and gender "construction as a constitutive constraint," (x) finds that it works by producing, as a side effect, "a domain of unthinkable, abject, unlivable bodies" (x), and sets about configuring this side effect as the raw material for bodily resignification. For Butler, resignification of these citations is the way out of the signifiatory circle.

- Bulter finds that **the body only materializes through language**. The reality of eating, sleeping, fucking, etc, is "irrefutable." "But," says Butler, "their irrefutability in no way implies what it might mean to affirm them and through what discursive means" (x).

She deploys examples of:

- Luce Irigaray's writing "citing" Plato;
- kinship practices in film *Paris Is Burning*;
- drag performance citing gender norms;
- most famously, by the reclamation of the word "queer" citing its own repudiation as an identity label.
 - emphasizes the radical possibility of queer, how it reiterates denigration to mean something else, a community with a future, with value, "resignifying the abjection of homosexuality into defiance and legitimacy" (xxviii).
- reads aristotle, freud, lacan, etc, to tease out the "indistinguishability of psychic and bodily formation" (xxix).

1.2 key terms/concepts

Resignification Process:

- The point isn't to demolish existing signifiatory systems, but to rework them in a process of resignification.
- Two steps:
 1. Repetition: What we think of as bodily materiality is a sedimentation that emerges from repetition, a kind of performance whereby meaning is signified and re-signified endlessly, never complete—citing whatever social power or understanding about sex.
 - Sex/gender are **unstable**, needing repetition:
 - * Sex/gender is never stable, that's why it needs repetition.
 - **Subjectivity** emerges in power structure:
 - * Subjects are always interpellated by the discourse prior to citing it. The subject only comes into intelligibility through the matrix of gender.
 2. Re-formulating repudiation, as a troubling return:
 - identification produces a repudiation, domain of abjection, which always threatens the boundaries of the identification:
 - * "The forming of a subject requires an identification with the normative phantasm of "sex," and this identification takes place through a repudiation which produces a **domain of abjection**, a repudiation without which the subject cannot emerge" (xiii).
 - * "this disavowed abjection will **threaten to expose** the self-grounding presumptions of the sexed subject, grounded as that subject is in a repudiation whose consequences it cannot fully control. The task will be to consider this threat and disruption not as a permanent contestation of social norms condemned to the pathos of perpetual failure, but rather as a critical resource in the struggle to rearticulate the very terms of symbolic legitimacy and intelligibility" (xiii).
 - The only freedom that is possible resides within this power of discourse, resignifying it, perhaps through parody or impersonation.
 - * Agency:

- * "The compulsion to repeat an injury is not necessarily the compulsion to repeat the injury in the same way or to stay fully within the traumatic orbit of that injury. The force of repetition in language may be the paradoxical condition by which a certain agency—not linked to a fiction of the ego as master of circumstance—is derived from the impossibility of choice. . . . Paris is Burning might be understood as repetitions of hegemonic forms of power that fail to repeat loyally and, in that failure, open possibilities for resignifying the terms of violation against their violating aims" (383).
- * "My purpose here is to understand how what has been foreclosed or banished from the proper domain of "sex" – where that domain is secured through a heterosexualizing imperative – might at once be produced as a **troubling return**, not only as an *imaginary* contestation that effects a failure in the workings of the inevitable law, but as an enabling disruption, the occasion for a radical rearticulation of the symbolic horizon in which bodies come to matter at all" (XXX).
- Examples of resignification that draws from repudiation:
 - * We see this in the word "queer" which has been re-appropriated—something that signified abjectness now means defiance. We can also use repetition to re-signify identification, to the point where it loses its power.
 - * In Paris is Burning, not only are the male drag performer exposing the superficiality of gender, but also performing care in away that is feminine, "mothering" "housing" "rearing" each other.

Language:

- language is productive, can resignify meaning. It is the option available to those who are trapped within the signification system.
 - "The body posited as prior to the sign, is always posited or signified as prior. This signification produces as an effect of its own procedure the very body that it nevertheless and simultaneously claims to discover as that which precedes its own action. If the body signified as prior to signification is an effect of signification,

then the mimetic or representational status of language, which claims that signs follow bodies as their necessary mirrors, is not mimetic at all. On the contrary, it is productive, constitutive, one might even argue performative, inasmuch as this signifying act delimits and contours the body that it then claims to find prior to any and all signification." (6).

On proliferation:

1.3 close readings

On *Paris is Burning*:

- "This "being a man" and this "being a woman" are internally unstable affairs. They are always beset by ambivalence precisely because there is a cost in every identification, the loss of some other set of identifications, the forcible approximation of a norm one never chooses, a norm that chooses us, but which we occupy, reverse, resignify to the extent that the norm fails to determine us completely." (86).
- when resignification doesn't always work, Venus Xtravaganza:
 - "The citing of the dominant norm does not, in this instance, displace that norm; rather, it becomes the means by which that dominant norm is most painfully reiterated as the very desire and the performance of those it subjects... As much as she crosses gender, sexuality, and race performatively, the hegemony that reinscribes the privileges of normative femininity and whiteness wields the final power to re-naturalize Venus's body and cross out that prior crossing, an erasure that is her death" (91).
- Kinship norms are resignified:
 - "it is in the elaboration of kinship forged through a resignification the very terms which effect our exclusion and abjection that such a resignification creates the discursive and social space for community, that we see an appropriation of the terms of domination that turns them toward a more enabling future." (95).

Drag and heterosexual melancholia:

- "that drag exposes or allegorizes the mundane psychic and performative practices by which heterosexualized genders form themselves

through the renunciation of the possibility of homosexuality, a foreclosure that produces a field of heterosexual objects at the same time that it produces a domain of those whom it would be impossible to love. Drag thus allegorizes heterosexual melancholy, the melancholy by which a masculine gender is formed from the refusal to grieve the masculine as a possibility of love; a feminine gender is formed (taken on, assumed) through the incorporative fantasy by which the feminine is excluded as a possible object of love, an exclusion never grieved, but “preserved” through the heightening of feminine identification itself. In this sense, the “truest” lesbian melancholic is the strictly straight woman, and the “truest” gay male melancholic is the strictly straight man” (180).

- "The critical promise of drag does not have to do with the proliferation of genders, as if a sheer increase in numbers would do the job, but rather with the exposure or the failure of heterosexual regimes ever fully to legislate or contain their own ideals" (181).

On Irigaray:

- "For how can one read a text for what does *not* appear within its own terms, but which nevertheless constitutes the illegible conditions of its own legibility? (11)
- One cannot interpret the philosophical relation to the feminine through the figures that philosophy provides, but, rather, she argues, through siting [sic] the feminine as the unspeakable condition of figuration, as that which, in fact, can never be figured within the terms of philosophy proper, but whose exclusion from that propriety is its enabling condition" (12).
 - "This is a taking of his [Plato's] place, not to assume it, but to show that it is *occupiable*. . . a kind of overreading which mimes and exposes the speculative excesses in Plato (emphasis original, 11).
- "This explains in part the radical citational practice of Irigaray, the catachrestic usurpation of the “proper” for fully improper purposes. For she mimes philosophy—as well as psychoanalysis—and, in the mime, takes on a language that effectively cannot belong to her, only to call into question the exclusionary rules of proprietariness that govern the use of that discourse. This contestation of propriety and property is

precisely the option open to the feminine when it has been constituted as an excluded impropriety, as the improper, the propertyless" (12).

- "Irigaray's response to this exclusion of the feminine from the economy of representation... I'll show you what this unintelligible receptacle can do to your system; I will not be a poor copy in your system, but I will resemble you nevertheless by miming the textual passages through which you construct your system and showing that **what cannot enter it is already inside it (as its necessary outside)**, and I will mime and repeat the gestures of your operation until this emergence of the outside within the system calls into question its systematic closure and its pretension to be self-grounding... In this sense, she performs a repetition and displacement of the phallic economy. This is citation, not as enslavement or simple reiteration of the original, but as an insubordination that appears to take place within the very terms of the original, and which calls into question the power of origination that Plato appears to claim for himself. Her miming has the effect of repeating the origin only to displace that origin as an origin" (18).
- On "matter" association to femininity:
 - "Irigaray's task... is to show that those binary oppositions are formulated through the exclusion of a field of disruptive possibilities. Her speculative thesis is that those binaries, even in their reconciled mode, are part of a phallogocentric economy that produces the "feminine" as its constitutive outside. Irigaray's intervention in the history of the form/matter distinction underscores "matter" as the site at which the feminine is excluded from philosophical binaries" (10).
 - "The economy that claims to include the feminine as the subordinate term in a binary opposition of masculine/feminine excludes the feminine, produces the feminine as that which must be excluded for that economy to operate" (10).
 - "every explicit distinction takes place in an inscriptional space that the distinction itself cannot accommodate. Matter as a *site* of inscription cannot be explicitly thematized. And this inscriptional site or space is, for Irigaray, a *materiality* that is not the same category of "matter" whose articulation it conditions and enables... this second inarticulate "matter" designates the constitutive outside of the Platonic economy; it is what must be excluded for that economy to posture as internally coherent" (12-13).

- A fount for future subversions:
 - "The task is to refigure this necessary "outside" as a future horizon, one in which the violence of exclusion is perpetually in the process of being overcome. But of equal importance is the preservation of the outside, the site where discourse meets its limits, where the opacity of what is not included in a given regime of truth acts as a disruptive site of linguistic impropriety and unrepresentability, illuminating the violent and contingent boundaries of that normative regime precisely through the inability of that regime to represent that which might pose a fundamental threat to its continuity. In this sense, **radical and inclusive representability is not precisely the goal**: to include, to speak as, to bring in every marginal and excluded position within a given discourse is to claim that a singular discourse meets its limits nowhere, that it can and will domesticate all signs of difference. If there is a violence necessary to the language of politics, then the risk of that violation might well be followed by another in which we begin, without ending, without mastering, to own—and yet never fully to own—the exclusions by which we proceed." (25).
 - She (like Munoz, Love?) is looking toward the horizon, where queerness can never be defined, but must remain the outside that delimits the known. The goal is not to be inclusive, it's to preserve this space that cannot be included without being coopted.

1.4 critiques

1.4.1 Jay Prosser

- Butler finds that the body only materializes through language/norms. The reality of eating, sleeping, fucking, etc, is "irrefutable." "But," says Butler, "their irrefutability in no way implies what it might mean to affirm them and through what discursive means" (x).

1.4.2 Martha Nussbaum

- Thinks Butler's politics are ineffective, weak, doesn't serve women.
 - "A new and disquieting trend" in feminism. . . "virtually complete turning from the material side of life, toward a type of verbal and symbolic politics that makes only the flimsiest of connections with the real situation of women."

- Nussbaum claims that Butler's position encourages feminists to "adopt a stance that looks like quietism and retreat".
- Critique of writing style, "teasing, exasperating" style that "bullies the reader". Not philosophy, but "sophistry and rhetoric".
 - Butler's style of posing questions - "mystification as well as hierarchy are the tools of her practice." "Butler never quite tells the reader whether she approves of the view described."
- Biggest critique: that parody and subversion are weak tools:
 - "What exactly does she council when she councils subversion?"
 - Slavery wasn't overcome through parody.
 - Parody won't work for women who are "hungry, illiterate, disenfranchised, beaten, raped... Such women prefer schools, votes, and the integrity of their bodies."